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Effective Representation of Muslim MPs in the Indian Parliament

Abstract

This study investigates the institutional determinants of effective parliamentary participation by Muslim Members of Parliament (MPs) in India, with a specific focus on their engagement during Question Hour. Drawing on a merged dataset from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data, the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project, and a manually coded list of Muslim MPs, we examine how political and institutional variables shape minority engagement within the legislature. Using regression and residualization techniques to control for structural confounders, we find that inclusive governance practices—such as equal legal protection, democratic coalition behavior, and open public discourse—are positively associated with Muslim MP activity. Conversely, higher formal democracy scores and horizontal accountability sometimes correspond with lower minority engagement, reflecting persistent informal barriers. Surprisingly, religious repression and exclusionary politics also predict increased participation, suggesting a form of reactive or contentious representation. These findings challenge simplistic assumptions about democracy and representation, highlighting the complex relationship between institutional context and the political voice of religious minorities.

Literature Review

At India's independence, the Constituent Assembly, having examined the alternatives, chose to recommend the parliamentary system¹. Through a process of continuous scrutiny,

¹ Shirin M. Rai and Carole Spary, "Women Members of Parliament: Presence and Participation in Parliamentary Debates," in *Performing Representation: Women Members in the Indian Parliament* (Oxford University Press, 2018).

debate and discussion, this system was believed to shape governance in a more accountable and inclusive manner². To facilitate engagement by elected representatives, the Indian Parliament was designed with several formal avenues, such as Question Hour, Zero Hour, and legislative debates on private member bills, motions, and participation in parliamentary committees³. These tools were intended to foster deliberation and transparency by enabling MPs to question the executive, shape policy, shape broader public discourse and raise issues of their constituents in the national forum. The promise of parliamentary democracy is not just about the election of representatives, but their meaningful participation in the legislative process. However, the distribution of this participation is not uniform. It is constrained by several structural, institutional, and social hierarchies that often determine who can speak, how frequently, and on what.

These constraints often manifest due to the procedural and informal dynamics that affect access to the floor. Mücke distinguishes between descriptive representation, which focuses on who holds office, and substantive representation, which concerns how officeholders act — specifically, whether they can “act in the interests of the represented in a manner responsive to them⁴”. Even when historically disadvantaged groups have descriptive representation, their substantive participation is commonly constrained by institutional norms, social expectations, and informal hierarchies. For example, speaking time in legislative debates is allocated party-wise⁵. This often means that the distribution of this time is strongly influenced by inter-party dynamics such as seniority and loyalty⁶. Additionally, cultural capital, as well as fluency and rhetorical ability in dominant languages such as Hindi and English, subtly determine an MP’s perceived “suitability” to represent the party on

² Ibid

³ Ibid

⁴ Mücke, Liza M., Daphne J. van der Pas, and Marc van de Wardt. “Representing Their Own? Ethnic Minority Women in the Dutch Parliament.” *West European Politics* 42, no. 4 (February 27, 2019): 705–27. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402382.2019.1573036>.

⁵ Banerjee, Mouli, and Shirin M. Rai. “Parliament as a Workplace: Dilemmas of Vernacularisation and Professionalisation.” *Politics and Governance* 12 (July 24, 2024). <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.8196>.

⁶ Ibid

national platforms⁷. As Banerjee and Rai observe, “those who are new or not seen as charismatic, particularly women or MPs from marginalised backgrounds, often lack access to informal party networks that determine whose voices are amplified in Parliament⁸” (2024). This is further exacerbated by the concentration of visibility and opportunity handed to selected “‘star’ MP(s)⁹.”

Along with this, a growing body of research demonstrates that questions of when, how, and by whom the parliamentary platform can be accessed are deeply shaped by identity-based barriers. Women MPs face a “burden of representation”—where they are expected to embody and speak for their gender¹⁰. While data shows that median participation by women may rival or even exceed that of men, they remain underrepresented among the most frequent and visible speakers¹¹. More importantly, they are often constrained to speak on “soft” issues like education or welfare¹². This silences female voices on other topics such as defence and finance.

Despite the existence of constitutionally mandated reservations, Dalit MPs also face identity-based challenges. Dalit MPs—particularly young or first-time representatives—ask fewer questions and participate less frequently in debates than their counterparts¹³. These patterns do not simply reflect personal choices but rather show structural exclusion seen

⁷ Rai, Shirin M., and Carole Spary. “Women Members of Parliament: Presence and Participation in Parliamentary Debates.” In *Performing Representation: Women Members in the Indian Parliament*. Oxford University Press, 2018; Banerjee, Mouli, and Shirin M. Rai. “Parliament as a Workplace: Dilemmas of Vernacularisation and Professionalisation.” *Politics and Governance* 12 (July 24, 2024). <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.8196>.

⁸ Banerjee, Mouli, and Shirin M. Rai. “Parliament as a Workplace: Dilemmas of Vernacularisation and Professionalisation.” *Politics and Governance* 12 (July 24, 2024). <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.8196>.

⁹ Ibid

¹⁰ Rai, Shirin M., and Carole Spary. “Women Members of Parliament: Presence and Participation in Parliamentary Debates.” In *Performing Representation: Women Members in the Indian Parliament*. Oxford University Press, 2018.

¹¹ Ibid

¹² Ibid

¹³ Sanyal, K. “Are Dalit Legislators Performing Their Oversight Role?.” In *Dalits in the New Millennium*. Cambridge University Press, 2023.

through limited access to mentorship, lack of research support, and constrained opportunities for political grooming¹⁴.

Even supposedly neutral tools like the Question Hour, which allow MPs to submit questions to ministers, reflect uneven patterns of usage that mirror broader social inequalities¹⁵. Kaushiki Sanyal finds that Question Hours are disproportionately used by socially dominant groups, indicating deeper institutional bias¹⁶. Participation is, therefore, mediated not only by procedural rules but also by identity-based hierarchies, party dynamics, social capital, and long-standing cultural and social norms¹⁷.

In this context, the participation of India's biggest minority, namely the Indian Muslims, becomes interesting. Despite making up nearly 14% of the population, Muslims have been consistently underrepresented, holding only 5–6% of Lok Sabha seats in recent decades¹⁸. Additionally, Zaman and Imtiyaz, in a study of parliamentary questions from 1999 to 2016, demonstrates that Muslim MPs disproportionately raise issues affecting their communities, while non-Muslim MPs—even from secular parties—rarely do so¹⁹. Hence, they argue that “the burden of voicing Muslim concerns in Parliament falls almost exclusively on Muslim MPs,” who are already a numerically small group.²⁰

¹⁴ Ibid

¹⁵ Adhya, Suman, and Debarshi Kr Sanyal. “What Does the Indian Parliament Discuss? An Exploratory Analysis of the Question Hour in the Lok Sabha,” 2023. <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2304.00235>.

¹⁶ Sanyal, K. “Are Dalit Legislators Performing Their Oversight Role? .” In *Dalits in the New Millennium*. Cambridge University Press, 2023.

¹⁷ Banerjee, Mouli, and Shirin M. Rai. “Parliament as a Workplace: Dilemmas of Vernacularisation and Professionalisation.” *Politics and Governance* 12 (July 24, 2024). <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.8196>.

¹⁸ Farooqui, Adnan. “Political Representation of a Minority: Muslim Representation in Contemporary India.” *India Review* 19, no. 2 (March 14, 2020): 153–75. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14736489.2020.1744996>.

¹⁹ Fakhruz-Zaman, and Aisha Imtiyaz. “Representing Indian Muslims: Parliamentary Questions as Instrument of Evaluating Substantive Representation in the Lok Sabha, 1999–2016.” In *Politics of Representation*, 161–81. Singapore: Springer Nature Singapore, 2022. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-19-1544-4_8.

²⁰ Ibid

Methodology

Dataset Used

We have used three uniquely different datasets from various sources to help with our analysis and answer our question. Two of the datasets are open source and are available on the internet while the other two datasets used are derived from scholarly work and their authors and derived from the open source dataset respectively.

The first dataset used is the Trivedi Centre for Political Data (TCPD)'s "Indian Parliament Dataset (Question Hour) 1.0" dataset²¹. This is an open source dataset that details all the Parliamentary Questions raised in the Lok Sabha by MPs between the year 1999 and 2019. This covered all the questions from 13th till the 16th Lok Sabha. This dataset was created by Saloni Bhogale by scraping data from the Lok Sabha's official website. With 15 variables present, this dataset presented to us the name of the MP, their party affiliation, constituency and its type, state, gender, question asked and their answer²².

We chose this dataset as it helps us in quantitatively assessing the parliamentary activity of the MPs with focus on their participation in Question Hour. As mentioned above, we used this as a proxy to indicate legislative engagement and accountability of the leader helping us operationalise our Dependent Variables (DV) and Independent Variables (IV). Given that we are focusing on the effective representation of Muslim MPs, the dataset helps us out by providing pertinent information like number of questions asked, the identities of MPs, their affiliation. These allow us to measure the quality of their representation not just in terms of their presence but rather through active participation.

²¹Saloni Bhogale and Trivedi Centre for Political Data, Ashoka University. "TPCD-IPD: TCPD Indian Parliament Dataset (Question Hour) 1.0," 2019.

²² For a quick overview of the TCPD dataset and its variables, the TCPD codebook can be accessed [here](#)

The second dataset used is the V-Dem Dataset²³ is a comprehensive democracy rating dataset that was released in March 2025. Originally, the study spans across 182 countries and contains data from 1900-2024. This provided us with exhaustive data for variables and indexes present that helped us use them as controls²⁴. V-Dem accumulates this data by using a detailed, expert-driven questionnaire and maintaining a database of coded responses. These responses are processed through a Bayesian model to account for coder bias and uncertainty. The rationale behind choosing the V-Dem dataset is for its comprehensive institutional and political indicators. These indicators help us control for the structural factors that may influence the effectiveness of Muslim MPs. Variables in the study allow us to contextualise the parliamentary participation of Muslim MPs within India's political landscape. These controls helped us isolate the role of identity in shaping parliamentary behavior from the institutional conditions under which MPs operate.

The third dataset was created after filtering for all the unique MPs that have asked questions in the Lok Sabha over time. We then downloaded the variable into a file and manually coded whether they were Muslim or not. We took two factors into account, the name and surname of the MP and their parents', partner's and children's name and then assigned whether they are a Muslim MP or not. If there was no data on kin but checked the first factor, then we looked at the constituency or made an educated guess.

Operationalising Variables (IV and DV)

Since this is an explanatory research we have tried to understand all the available factors from the dataset that could affect the parliamentary participation of Muslim MPs (DV). Our IVs have been inherited from the various variables and indices (indicators) available in the V-Dem Dataset. We have done two main things, estimate a clean association

²³ Coppedge, M., Gerring, J., Lindberg, S. I., Teorell, J., Altman, D., Bernhard, M., ... & Wilson, S. (2025). V-Dem [Country–Year/Country–Date] Dataset v15 [Version 15]. Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project. <https://doi.org/10.23696/vdemds25>

²⁴ For a quick overview of the V-Dem dataset and its variables, the V-Dem codebook can be accessed [here](#)

between each indicator and Muslim MPs' question-asking behaviour and plot and report statistically significant relationships showcasing the variables that have meaningful effects.

To do so for the IVs, we create a dictionary of variables from the V-Dem Dataset. We then created a dataframe that stored each variable name and their label, the regression beta, p-value and the confidence interval. We used a regression beta to show the magnitude of association between the IV and DV. A positive beta shows that Muslim MPs ask more questions, after controlling for confounders, while a negative beta shows they ask fewer questions. It also serves as a double check as a statistically significant result may be meaningless if the effect size is small.

To gain insight into the unique association of each predictor with the number of questions asked by Muslim MPs more fully, we used a residualization method²⁵. This meant removing the impact of a set of control variables — whether the MP was a member of the ruling coalition (`same_as_ruling`), how many questions asked by non-Muslim MPs, the state-year average of questions asked, and whether the legislature was directly elected (`v2xel_elecparl`). We started by doing regressions to predict both our dependent variable (Muslim MP questions) and each of our predictors on these control variables. The residual variation — what remained after the controls had been accounted for — was used in our analysis. By plotting these "residualized"²⁶ values and estimating a simple linear model, we were then able to examine the direct relationship between each of the predictors and Muslim MP question-asking behavior, controlling for the effect of the control variables. This is done to restrict confounding variable bias and render it easier to understand the effect of each of the variables on a multifaceted observational data set.

²⁵ Wurm, Lee H., and Sebastiano A. Fisicaro. "What Residualizing Predictors in Regression Analyses Does (and What It Does Not Do)." *Journal of Memory and Language* 72 (April 2014): 37–48. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2013.12.003>.

²⁶ Wurm, Lee H., and Sebastiano A. Fisicaro. "What Residualizing Predictors in Regression Analyses Does (and What It Does Not Do)." *Journal of Memory and Language* 72 (April 2014): 37–48. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2013.12.003>.

Results and Analysis

1. National Variation in Parliamentary Participation

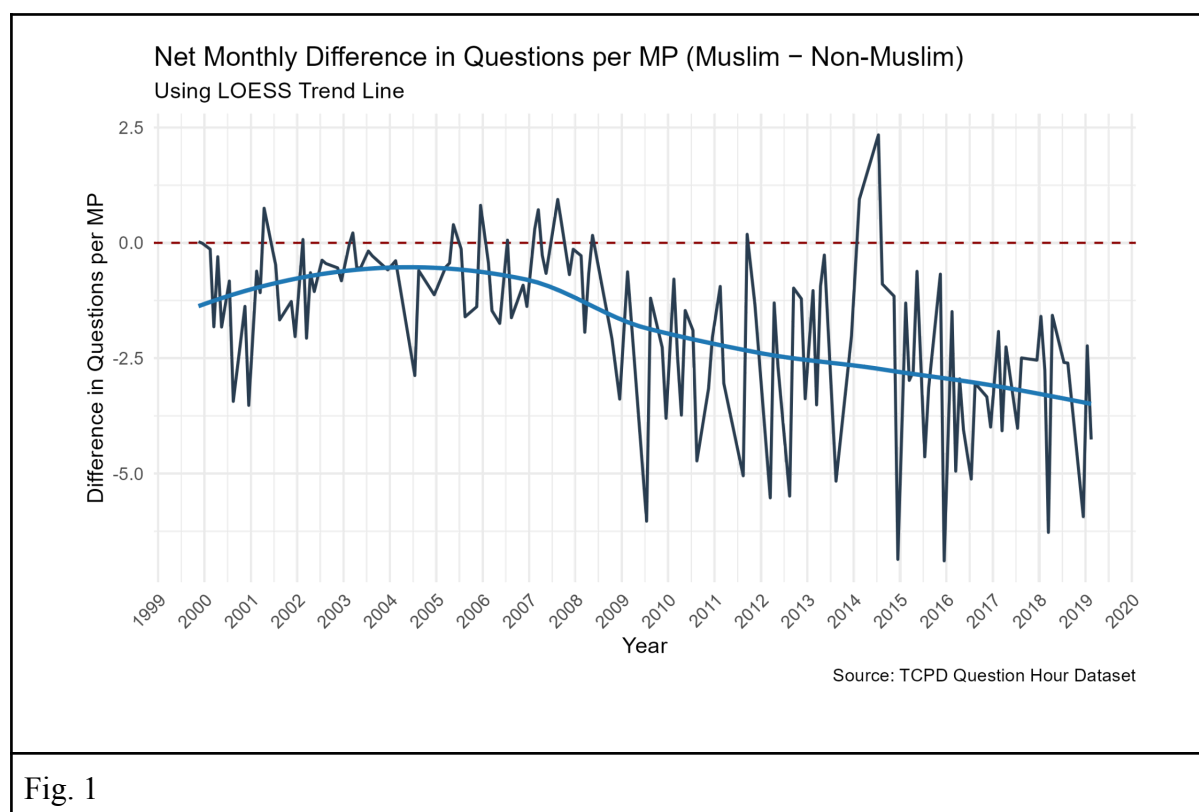


Fig. 1

Figure 1 displays the monthly net difference in questions per MP between Muslims and Non-Muslims. In other words, each point on the graph measures the difference in means —*Average Questions per Muslim MP – Average Questions per Non Muslim MP*— at that point.

The trend shows that till around the early 2000s, the difference fluctuates around zero, indicating a broad parity in participation. However, since 2006, the disparity between the questions asked per Muslim and Non-Muslim MP increases. Interestingly, there is a sharp spike in late 2014, where Muslim MPs asked significantly more questions than their counterparts.

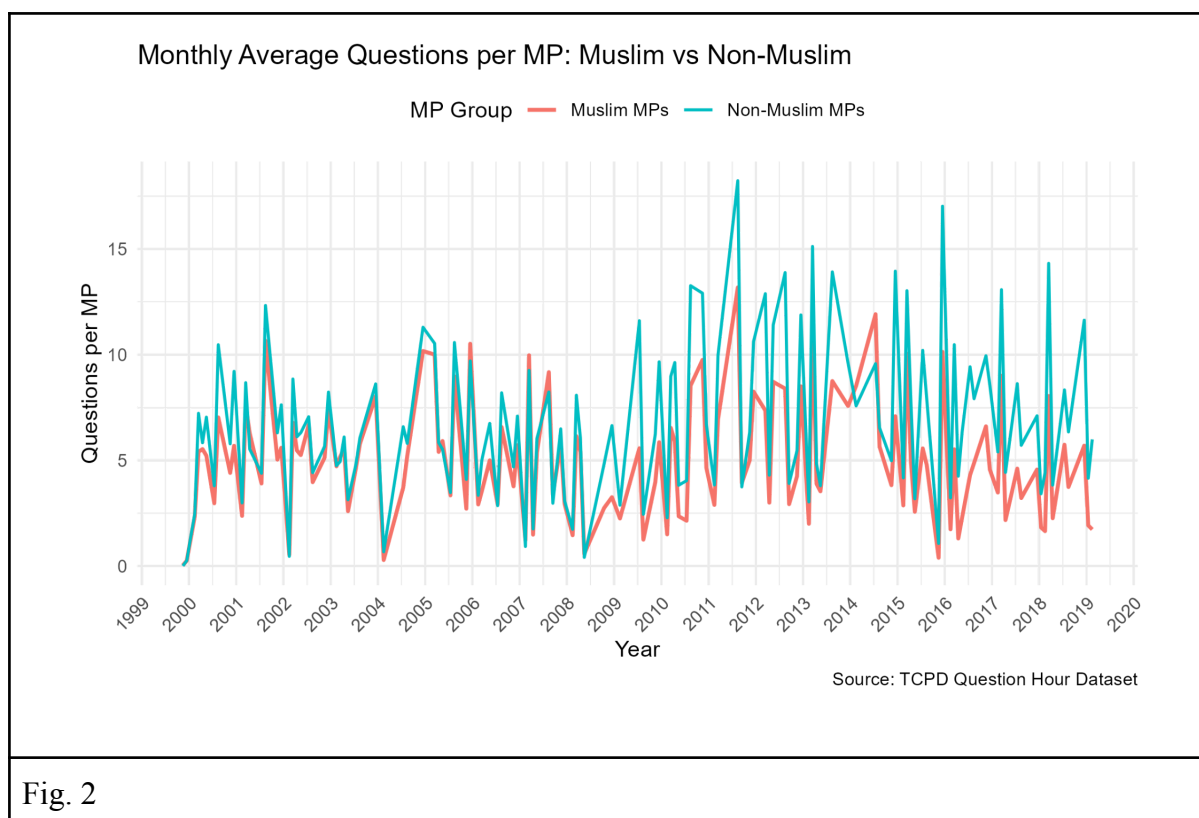


Fig. 2

Figure 2 reinforces the above observation. It plots the average number of questions asked per MP each month from 2000 to 2019, disaggregated by religious identity. As in the previous graph, Muslim and Non-Muslim MPs asked questions in similar levels in the early 2000s. However, there is a noticeable divergence post-2009. Non-Muslim MPs show an upward trajectory in question-asking, while the engagement of Muslim MPs begins to stagnate or decline.

2. State-Level Variation in Parliamentary Engagement

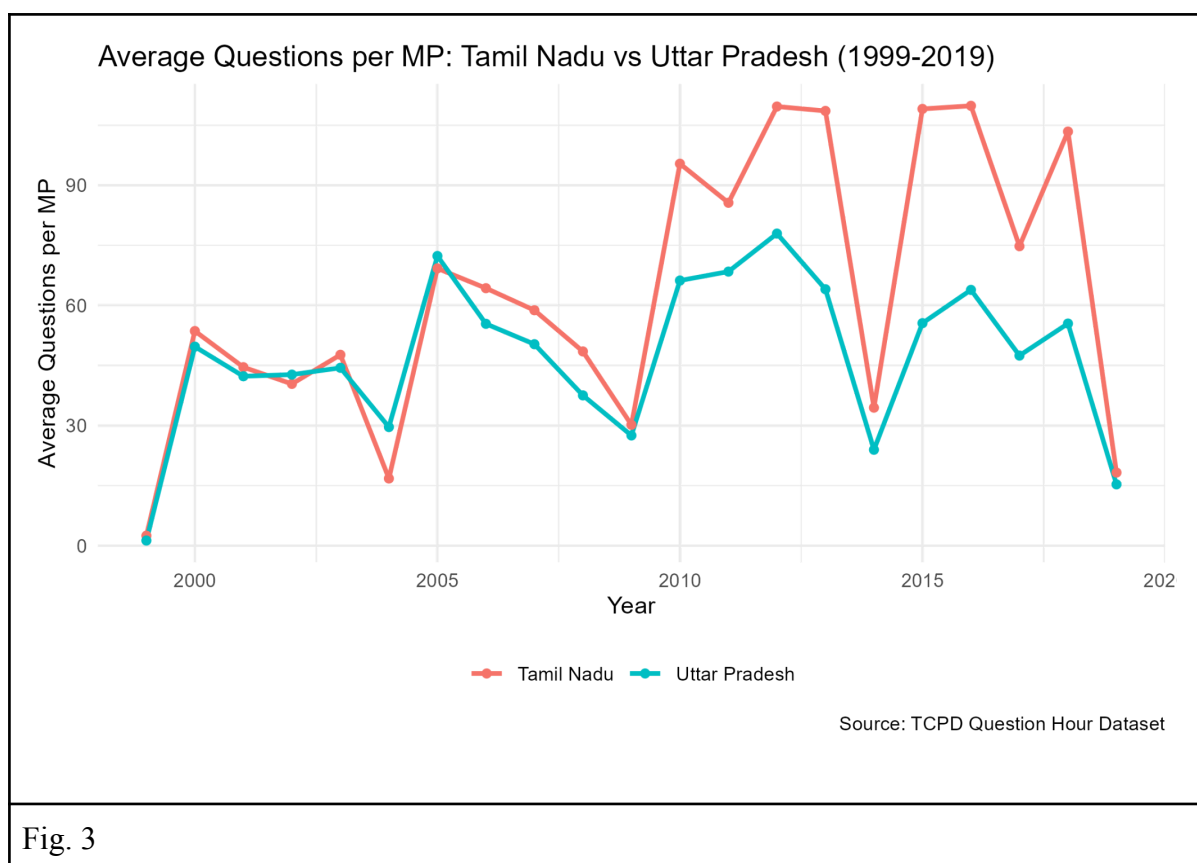


Fig. 3

National patterns are further complicated by regional variation in MP behaviour.

Figure 3 compares the average annual number of questions asked per MP in Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh between 1999 and 2019. While both states exhibited comparable levels of engagement in the early 2000s, post-2010, there is a growing disparity between the two. MPs from Tamil Nadu consistently ask a higher number of questions, frequently averaging over 90 questions per year, whereas MPs from Uttar Pradesh often stay closer to 50 or below.

This divergence emphasises the influence of state-level political cultures and institutional norms on legislative behaviour. The higher engagement in Tamil Nadu may reflect the influence of regional party systems and stronger constituency service norms. This variation hence motivates the inclusion of state-level controls in the measure of questions asked by Muslim MPs, to ensure that regional patterns do not confound the relationships under investigation.

3. Summary of Key Predictors

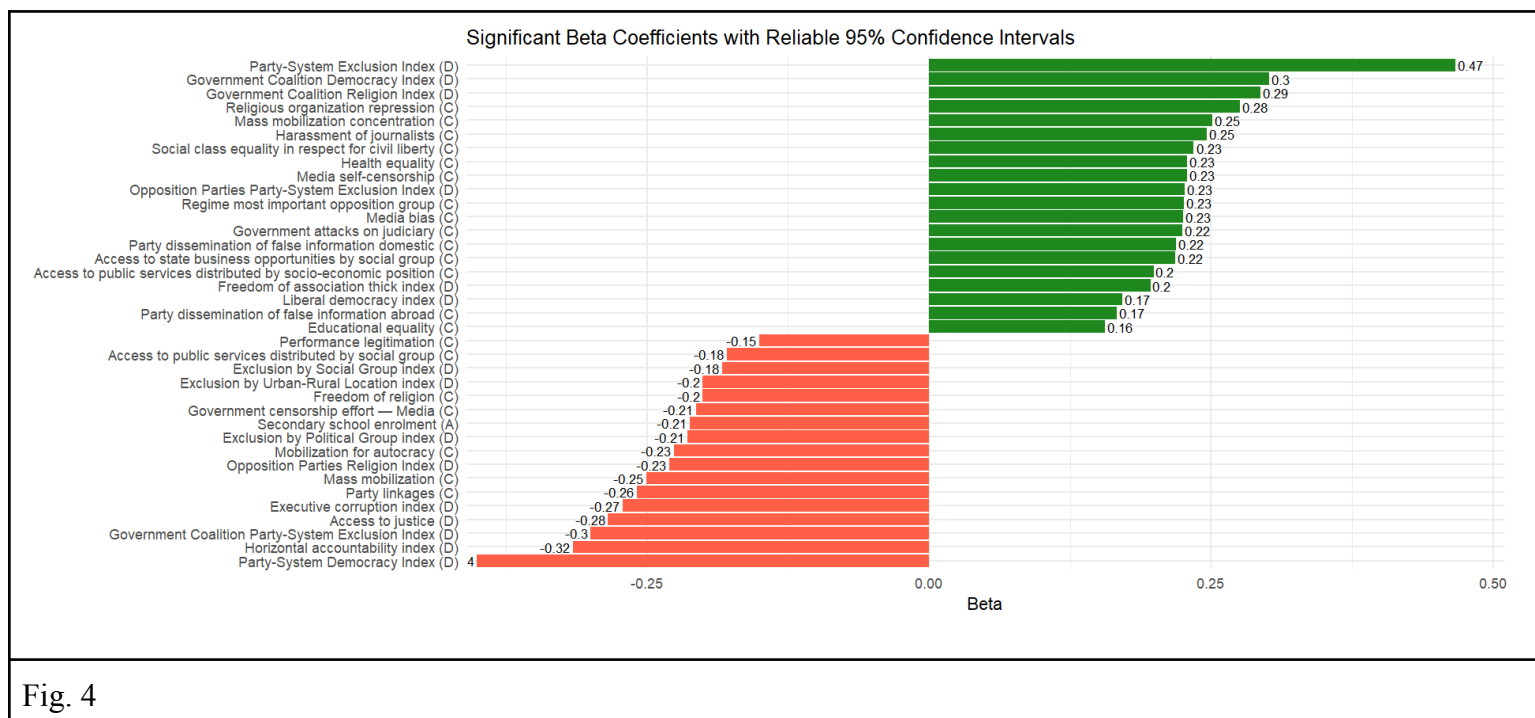


Fig. 4

Having established national and religious variation, Figure 4 attempts to identify and isolate institutional and political factors that may shape these patterns. This plot visualises standardised beta coefficients from residualised regression models between questions asked per Muslim MPs and different variables from the VDem dataset. The residualised models that are plotted here were created by removing the influence of control variables (election timing, ruling coalition alignment, non-Muslim MP activity, and average state-level question counts) from both the outcome and the predictor, and then examining their partial relationship. Thus, each coefficient value represents the strength and direction of the relationship in isolation.

Importantly, this graph only shows those relations that are statistically significant, and whose 95% confidence intervals do not cross zero – ensuring that only the most robust associations are featured.

A positive beta coefficient indicates that increases in that variable is associated with a greater number of questions asked per Muslim MP. This can be seen in high equal protection,

civil liberties, or coalition inclusion. Meanwhile, a negative value of the coefficient indicates a suppressive effect of the variable, as seen in high systemic exclusion or higher upholding of democratic ideals by the party system.

4. Visualising Residualized Relationships

To complement the findings of Figure 4, we also created a set of residualised scatterplots to visualise the isolated relationship between some key predictors and Muslim MP participation. As before, the effect of controls is removed from both the independent and the dependent variables being tested.

As used in the earlier section, and as in the rest of this study, the following were controlled for:

- whether a national election was held during the period (v2xel_elecparl)
- whether the MP's party was part of the ruling coalition (same_as_ruling)
- the average number of questions asked by non-Muslim MPs
(questions_per_non_muslim_mp)
- and the average number of questions asked in that state and year
(avg_questions_state_year)

Each graph plots residualized values for the institutional predictor on the x-axis and residualized Muslim MP questions on the y-axis. Points are individual MP-month observations, colored by year, with darker colours representing more recent years. The black line indicates a linear fit.

Religious Organisation Repression

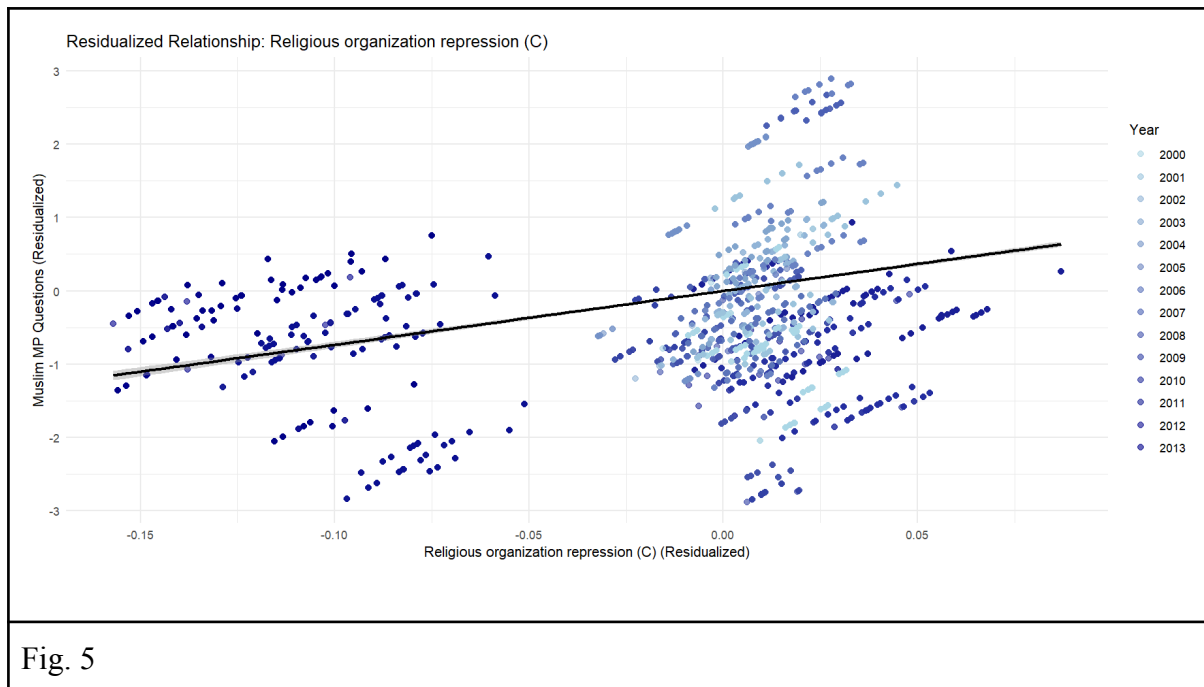


Fig. 5

The scatterplot, Figure 5, shows a positive relationship between the repression of religious organisations and the number of questions asked by Muslim MPs. As values of repression increase, the average y-axis values of the residual points shift upwards. The points are tightly clustered in the middle range near zero. However, even on the higher and lower repressions, the direction of the fit line remains, aided by clearly higher point densities in the upper right and lower left quadrants.

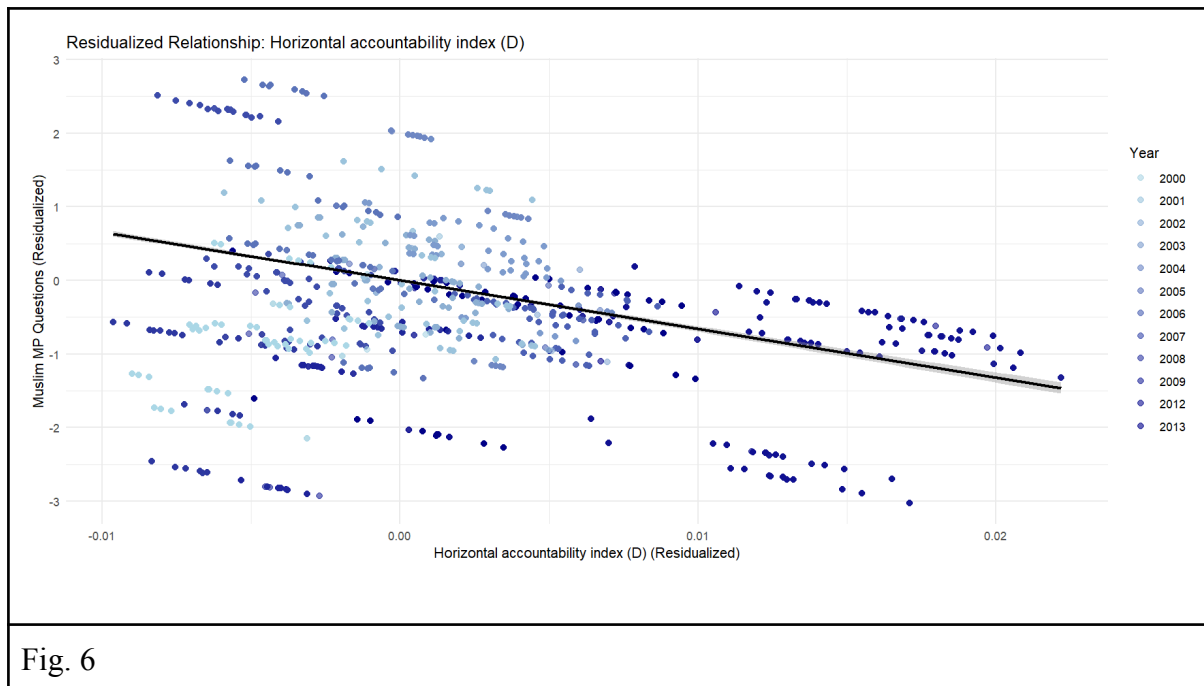
Horizontal Accountability Index

Fig. 6

Figure 6 shows that higher values of horizontal accountability, or institutional checks on the executive, are associated with lower levels of Muslim MP participation through questions.

The residual points are spread across the graph, yet the negative trend is consistent across the full range of the x-axis. This may indicate structural marginalisation of Muslims, or a lower perceived need for scrutiny due to strong institutional oversight mechanisms.

Freedom of Discussion

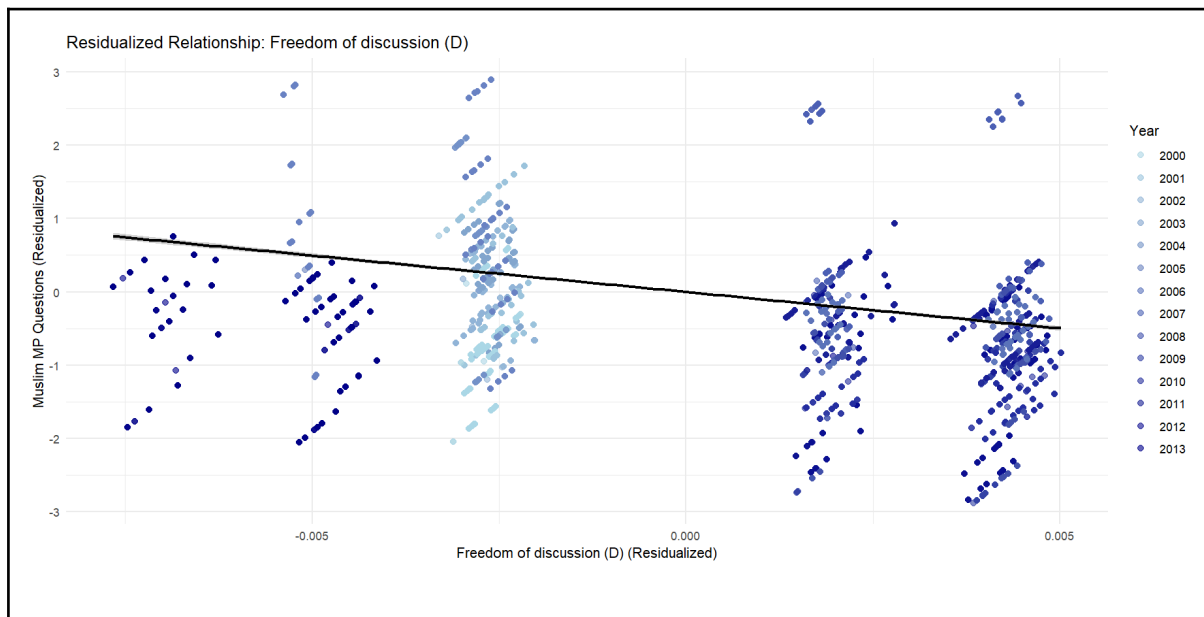


Fig. 7

The plot for the freedom of discussion index vs questions per Muslim MP is more fragmented than those in Figure 5 and Figure 6. This could be because of the ordinal nature of the freedom index values in the dataset. However, we can still see a general negative trend. It is possible that this trend indicates a greater reliance on non-formal institutions to raise concerns due to the more unencumbered political speech.

Equal Protection Index

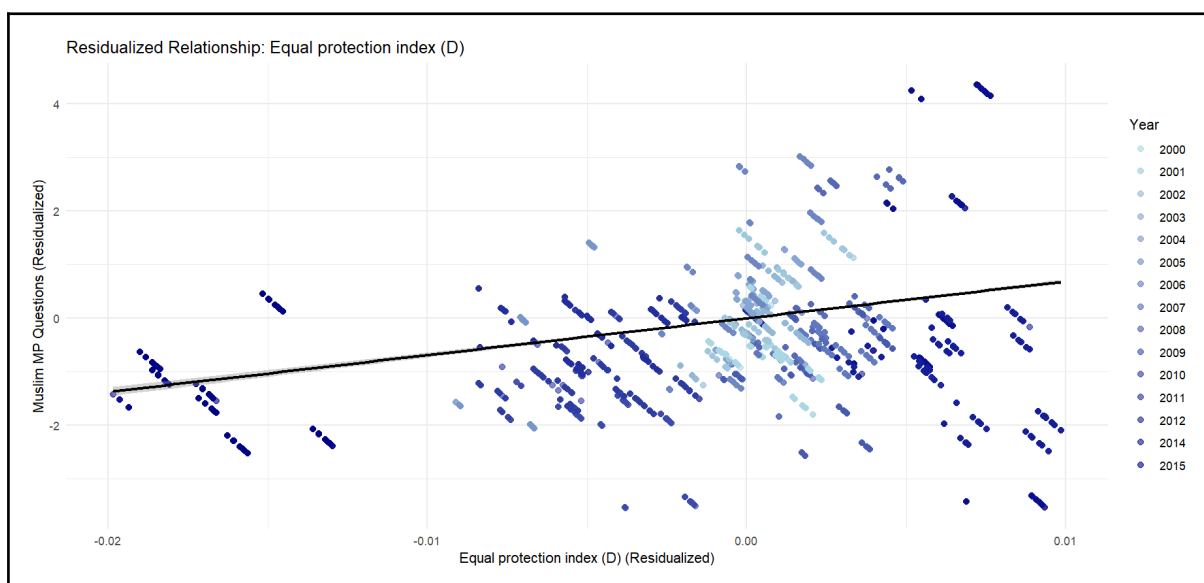


Fig. 8

Figure 8 shows a strong positive trend. As the state's protection of different social groups becomes more uniform, Muslim MP participation increases. The residual points are dense and more symmetrically placed than in previous plots. A greater sense of protection of rights and freedom, regardless of (here) religion, could be empowering Muslim MPs to be more vocal in the parliament.

5. Regression Analysis: Institutional Predictors of Muslim MP Participation

To further support the effects of variables shown in Figure 4, we estimate linear regressions predicting the number of questions asked by Muslim MPs per month with selected variables. Each model includes a key predictor along with the same consistent set of controls used in the summary plot.

Equal Protection Index (v2xeg_eqprotec)

Regression Output for Equal protection index (D)	
=====	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	

predictor	23.779*** (0.371)
v2xel_elecpa1	-0.032 (0.033)
same_as_ruling	0.052* (0.028)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.647*** (0.003)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.004*** (0.0003)
Constant	-14.799*** (0.249)

Observations	19,459
R2	0.763
Adjusted R2	0.763
Residual Std. Error	1.321 (df = 19453)
F Statistic	12,528.560*** (df = 5; 19453)
=====	

This variable measures how uniform state protection of rights and freedoms is across different social groups. In our analysis, it has a large and positive effect of 23.78 (SE = 0.371, $p < 0.01$). That is, the greater the equality of protection by the state, the greater the mean number of Muslim MP questions.

Government Coalition Democracy Index (v2xpas_democracy_government)

Regression Output for Government Coalition Democracy Index (D)	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	
predictor	2.527*** (0.172)
v2xe1_elecpar1	
same_as_ruling	0.146 (0.161)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.661*** (0.017)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.005 (0.004)
Constant	0.260 (0.192)
Observations	2,153
R2	0.448
Adjusted R2	0.447
Residual Std. Error	2.316 (df = 2148)
F Statistic	435.301*** (df = 4; 2148)

This index measures the degree to which governing parties are devoted to democratic standards in the pre-election period. An increased value indicates a more democratic coalition. Increasing by one unit forecasts 2.53 more questions for every Muslim MP (SE = 0.172, $p < 0.01$), and it implies that Muslim MPs participate more when the governing coalition is seen as being more democratic.

Government Coalition Religion Index (v2xpas_religion_government)

Regression Output for Government Coalition Religion Index (D)	
=====	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	

predictor	3.687*** (0.259)
v2xe1_elecpar1	
same_as_ruling	0.096 (0.162)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.659*** (0.017)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.008** (0.004)
Constant	-0.456** (0.216)

Observations	2,153
R2	0.445
Adjusted R2	0.444
Residual Std. Error	2.322 (df = 2148)
F Statistic	430.429*** (df = 4; 2148)
=====	

This index examines the extent to which religion is invoked by the governing coalition in decision-making. A unit increase is linked to 3.69 additional questions per Muslim MP (SE = 0.259, $p < 0.01$). This may be indicative of more active participation in settings where religious identity is politicised.

Religious Organisation Repression (v2csr1gsep)

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Regression Output for Religious organization repression (C)
=====
Dependent variable:
-----
questions_per_muslim_mp
-----
predictor                1.677***
                        (0.030)
v2xel_elecpar1           0.395***
                        (0.033)
same_as_ruling           0.103***
                        (0.028)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp 0.668***
                        (0.003)
avg_questions_state_year -0.003***
                        (0.0003)
Constant                 -0.150***
                        (0.038)
-----
Observations              19,459
R2                        0.754
Adjusted R2               0.754
Residual Std. Error       1.346 (df = 19453)
F Statistic               11,921.900*** (df = 5; 19453)
=====

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As the title implies, this measures the degree to which religious groups are suppressed. The coefficient is 1.68 (SE = 0.030, $p < 0.01$), suggesting greater participation in settings of religious suppression, possibly as a means of advocacy or protest.

Party-System Democracy Index (v2xpas_democracy)

Regression Output for Party-System Democracy Index (D)	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	
predictor	
	-10.939*** (0.539)
v2xel_elecpar1	
same_as_ruling	0.154 (0.154)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.646*** (0.016)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.008** (0.003)
Constant	7.706*** (0.363)
Observations	2,153
R2	0.490
Adjusted R2	0.489
Residual Std. Error	2.225 (df = 2148)
F Statistic	516.194*** (df = 4; 2148)

This variable evaluates the democratic nature of the overall party system. Here, the coefficient is negative: -10.94 (SE = 0.539, $p < 0.01$). This suggests that higher formal democracy scores may coincide with lower Muslim MP activity, potentially due to majoritarian dynamics within these systems.

Horizontal Accountability Index (v2x_horacc)

Regression Output for Horizontal accountability index (D)	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	
predictor	4.952*** (0.079)
v2xel_elecpar1	0.100*** (0.033)
same_as_ruling	0.052* (0.028)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.656*** (0.003)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.005*** (0.0003)
Constant	-3.988*** (0.086)
Observations	19,459
R2	0.761
Adjusted R2	0.761
Residual Std. Error	1.326 (df = 19453)
F Statistic	12,408.080*** (df = 5; 19453)

The index captures the robustness of checks by institutions on executive authority. The model exhibits a very high positive impact (4.95, SE = 0.079, $p < 0.01$), meaning that Muslim MP participation increases where there is more effective monitoring of executive action.

Government Coalition Party-System Exclusion Index (v2xpas_exclusion_government)

Regression Output for Government Coalition Party-System Exclusion Index	
=====	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	

predictor	-2.271*** (0.156)
v2xel_elecpar1	
same_as_ruling	0.122 (0.161)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.660*** (0.017)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.006* (0.004)
Constant	2.406*** (0.197)

Observations	2,153
R2	0.447
Adjusted R2	0.446
Residual Std. Error	2.318 (df = 2148)
F Statistic	434.123*** (df = 4; 2148)
=====	

This captures exclusionary sentiments within the coalition government. The coefficient is -2.27 (SE = 0.156, $p < 0.01$), confirming the proposition that exclusivist governments deter Muslim MP involvement.

Freedom of Discussion Index (v2xcl_disc)

Regression Output for Freedom of discussion (D)	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	
predictor	
	11.126*** (0.190)
v2xel_elecpar1	0.207*** (0.033)
same_as_ruling	0.044 (0.028)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.662*** (0.003)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.004*** (0.0003)
Constant	-7.449*** (0.148)
Observations	19,459
R2	0.756
Adjusted R2	0.756
Residual Std. Error	1.340 (df = 19453)
F Statistic	12,062.290*** (df = 5; 19453)

This variable measures how freely citizens can engage in political discussion. An increase of one unit predicts 11.13 additional questions per Muslim MP (SE = 0.190, $p < 0.01$), affirming the significance of public discourse in political participation.

Party-System Exclusion Index (v2xpas_exclusion)

Regression Output for Party-System Exclusion Index (D)	
Dependent variable:	
questions_per_muslim_mp	
predictor	
	19.123*** (0.783)
v2xel_elecpar1	
same_as_ruling	0.290* (0.149)
questions_per_non_muslim_mp	0.635*** (0.016)
avg_questions_state_year	-0.006* (0.003)
Constant	-10.459*** (0.507)
Observations	2,153
R2	0.525
Adjusted R2	0.524
Residual Std. Error	2.149 (df = 2148)
F Statistic	592.364*** (df = 4; 2148)

This measure reflects the extent to which the party system endorses exclusionary politics. The index has a positive coefficient of around 19.12 extra questions per Muslim MP per month (SE = 0.783, $p < 0.01$). This surprising result could indicate reactive behaviour on the part of Muslim MPs in more exclusionary settings.

Interpretation

The empirical patterns seen through the results make it difficult to paint a clear picture of what impacts religious minority political engagement in the parliament. Some indicators that are commonly associated with democracy and inclusivity appear to foster greater participation by Muslim MPs. For example, the regression and residualised scatterplots show that variables such as the Equal Protection Index and Government Coalition Democracy

Index have a strong positive effect. This suggests that a more inclusive legal framework and higher commitment to democracy can create a space for minority voices.

However, indicators like the Party-System Democracy Index, a broad measure of formal democratic structure, or the Horizontal Accountability Index, which measures checks on executive power, have a negative association with Muslim MP participation. This shows that democratic measures might not always translate to substantial participation of marginalised groups, possibly due to underlying non-inclusive power dynamics.

More interestingly, higher exclusion or repression might lead to greater participation of marginalised minority groups. The Party-System Exclusion Index and Religious Organisation Repression variable both show positive relationships with Muslim MP question-asking. This might reflect “Non-Extremist Outbidding” or the use of formal frameworks to demand greater rights and freedoms.

Taken together, these results motivate against a singular understanding of the impact of democracy, liberal norms or inclusivity on Muslim political participation in India.

Discussion

Our study takes place through a quantitative lens and after running statistical analysis, it is still not strong enough proof if it is not grounded in scholarly literature. In this section we will engage with what academicians say and help make our claim stronger.

Htun’s research can aid in understanding what we see with the Equal Protection Index and its effect on Muslim MPs. Htun, points out that "collective representational rights constitute part of the bargain struck to ensure the viability of democracy in a plural society," whereby "each group is guaranteed a share of power." These institutional and constitutional

protections are important for historically marginalised groups whose political membership cannot be taken for granted²⁷.

Our empirical observations verify this theoretical statement. Figure 8 illustrates this relationship by showing that as legal protections become stronger, Muslim MPs become more active in parliamentary questioning. This is synonymous with Htun's argument that formal equality is often insufficient without institutional mechanisms that guarantee minority inclusion.

The theory of consensual democracy by Lijphart makes a strong theory to understand the phenomena of why democratic governing coalitions are likely to foster increased participation from marginalised groups²⁸. This theory was developed to emphasise the shortcomings of majoritarian/ Westminster-type democracy in ethnically heterogeneous societies. Consensus democracy exhibits why power-sharing, proportional representation, broad coalition and inclusivity are suitable for societies where minority rights and participation are central to democratic legitimacy.

This directly ties to the quantitative findings that more democratic coalitions are associated with a significant increase in the number of questions asked by Muslim MPs. Hence, the implication is clear that the greater the degree to which the governing coalition expresses consensus-based values, the greater the legitimacy accorded to minority opinions in legislative institutions. In the Indian instance, where Muslim MPs are neither formally provided group-based reservations, strong democratic performance coalition governments can provide informal avenues of representation through membership within multi-party coalitions, selection to committees, or enhancement of parliamentary activism.

²⁷ Mala Htun, "Is Gender like Ethnicity? The Political Representation of Identity Groups," *Perspectives on Politics* 2, no. 03 (September 2004), <https://doi.org/10.1017/s1537592704040241>.

²⁸ Arend Lijphart, *Patterns of Democracy: Thirty-Six Democracies* (Yale University Press, 2012), <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt32bg23>.

The repression of religious groups is ordinarily understood as a proxy for more general restrictions on civil and political liberties. The author argues, in his book, that dominated groups are limited in mobilisation, definition of grievances, and influence on institutionally significant decisions because state repression (understood as majoritarian state) serves to produce 'political demobilisation'. Minorities' space for agency reduces, negatively impacting participation and representation, in the repressive environments²⁹.

Yet it was interesting to note that our empirical findings showed a paradoxical trend. The repression of religious organisations index positively and significantly affects Muslim MP activity in parliamentary questions. This implies that in the situation of increasing religious repression, Muslim MPs become politically engaged. This finding is consistent with the work of Boudreau, wherein he proposes the model of 'contentious participation'³⁰. This refers to the phenomenon when marginalised groups, when facing civil society constraints, turn to formal institutions like the legislature to express their grievances and use it as a sign of protest and visibility. This can be the explanation for why we see Muslim MPs using parliamentary platforms as a device to indicate disagreement, mobilise support and specify minority demands.

Voicing out for minorities is as important as public discourse. Only when political discourse is inclusive and open can it enhance civic engagement. And enhancing civic engagement gives minority concerns more priority. Open public spaces in societies can therefore facilitate the voice and discussion of marginalised communities. This is because openness to articulate concerns institutionalised norms of pluralism and makes it impossible for governments or parties to ignore minority demands³¹.

²⁹ Charles Tilly, *The Politics of Collective Violence* (Cambridge University Press, 2003), <https://doi.org/10.1017/cbo9780511819131>.

³⁰ Vincent Boudreau, *Resisting Dictatorship* (Cambridge University Press, 2004), <https://doi.org/10.1017/cbo9780511550867>.

³¹ Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart, *Sacred and Secular* (Cambridge University Press, 2004), <https://doi.org/10.1017/cbo9780511791017>.

Our finding confirms this positive relationship between freedom of political debate and Muslim MPs' legislative activities. We can thus identify that openness of communication serves as an enabling mechanism to empower Muslim MPs to engage actively in parliamentary agenda-setting. Interestingly, even with representation by institutions, whether MPs are actually able to express concerns effectively may depend on the overall communicative environment. Since public discussion is free and active, it highlights minority grievances and provides a voice for minority representatives. One is able to theorise, in a sense, from this fact that freedom of discussion is hardly a civil right but rather more of a stimulant of political action for minority groups.

Limitations

While our study offers insights into the reasons for increased or decreased participation of Muslim MPs in the Indian Parliament there are certain data and analytical constraints.

Firstly, as we manually identify the Muslim MPs based on names, kinship data and constituencies, it is susceptible to misclassification which could lead to different results.

Secondly, there is causal ambiguity present in the study. While our associations are statistically robust they may not be strictly causal. Even though we back our findings via existing literature, reverse causality is difficult to control. For example, higher Muslim MP engagement during periods of exclusion or repression may reflect self-selection or reverse causality, rather than a direct institutional effect.

Thirdly, our dataset is till the 16th Lok Sabha. The 17th Lok Sabha (2019-2024) saw some significant developments especially around religious polarisation so our time-bound dataset restricted our temporal analysis.

Lastly, the residualizing of values to isolate relations strengthens causal inference from observational data but at times over-corrects or obscures interactions between significant

variables. Residualization also assumes linearity in relations, which does not capture nuanced political dynamics.

Scope of Further Studies

The findings and the limitations of our study actually open up avenues for further research.

A comparative study of marginalised groups like Dalit MPs, Female MPs along with religious minorities MPs can be examined to see whether similar outcomes take place.

Qualitative elements can be used such as the tonality of the questions asked for further mixed methods analysis to see the type of questions Muslim MPs ask.

Expanding legislative engagement metrics by incorporating additional indicators of parliamentary activity such as bill sponsorship, committee participation, media presence, and constituency service can provide a fuller picture of Muslim MPs' substantive engagement.

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